



Prince William, second in line to the British throne, kisses his bride, Catherine Middleton, on the balcony of Buckingham Palace following their wedding at Westminster Abbey on April 29.

EXTRAORDINARY EVENTS ACROSS THE MIDDLE EAST led to what became known as the "**Arab Spring**." It began when a man in Tunisia burned himself to death in December 2010 in protest at his treatment by police. This led to pro-democracy rebellions, which erupted across the **Middle East**. After days of protests, Tunisian president Zine el Abidine Ben Ali promised more jobs while vowing to punish rioters. On January 9, protestors clashed with police and there were calls for the president to resign. A few days later he fled to Saudi Arabia.

Riots began in **Algeria** over food prices and unemployment. A man burned himself to death in an apparent echo of events in Tunisia that sent new shockwaves across North Africa. Antigovernment activists announced a "day of anger" in Egypt, and there were calls for **President Mubarak** (b. 1928) to resign. In response, Mubarak shut down cellphone and internet networks and then appointed his first-ever vice president in an attempt to calm things down. Eventually, after 18 solid days of mass protest, **Mubarak surrendered power** to the army on February 11 and flew out of Cairo.

The uprising in Egypt led to an upsurge of **violent protests** against repressive regimes in **Yemen, Jordan, Morocco, Oman, and Iran**. On February 16, protests erupted in Libya's second largest city, **Benghazi**, following the arrest of a human rights campaigner. The uprising against

Colonel Muammar Gaddafi (b. 1942) developed into an armed conflict pitting rebels against government forces. A NATO-led coalition with a UN mandate to protect civilians also became involved. The country's coastal cities became roughly split between pro-Gaddafi forces



Revolution in Egypt
An Egyptian man and boy celebrate the resignation of Egyptian President Hosni Mubarak in Tahir Square, Cairo after weeks of protests.

controlling the capital, Tripoli, and the west, and rebels controlling Benghazi in the east.

The wave of popular unrest also hit **Syria**, where the government began a violent crackdown on civilian dissenters. **President Assad** (b. 1965) promised reform on April 16, but the death toll rose and scores of prominent

intellectuals and activists went into hiding. Syrians demanded greater political freedom, an end to corruption, and the lifting of an emergency law in place for nearly 50 years.

There was cautious optimism in two African nations this year as they struggled to end years of bloody conflict. In January, the **Sudanese voted in a referendum** to split the country between north and south and form a new state. However, within months of the poll a wave of violence spread across southern Sudan as its army clashed with rebel militia. These rebel groups accused the government of plotting to stay in power indefinitely, not representing all tribal groups, and neglecting development in rural areas. This led to fears that **Southern Sudan** would fail as a country before it had even got started.

The **Ivory Coast** held elections in 2010. A high turnout fostered the belief that the country's post-civil war division might come to an end. The Constitutional Council named incumbent president **Laurence Gbagbo** the winner, but the electoral commission named **Alassane Ouattara**, who was immediately recognized by the UN, US, and the EU. Gbagbo fought to stay in power and there was fierce fighting between the two sides. The UN sent in troops, and on April 5 launched air attacks on Gbagbo's positions. Under the auspices of the UN, French helicopters attacked Gbagbo's palace on April 9 and he was arrested two days later. Ouattara



Broken city
A family walks past cars upturned by the tsunami in Japan. A massive 8.9 magnitude earthquake hit Sendai, the capital of the Miyagi Prefecture.

became president, but inherited a country politically and militarily divided, half destroyed by civil war, and with an economy starved of investment.

A series of **natural disasters** struck around the globe during the first few months of the year, causing unprecedented damage and destruction. Brisbane, **Australia**, resembled a muddy lake in January following catastrophic **flooding**, with debris from houses and

businesses washed away down the Brisbane River. The floods spread to other parts of Queensland—more than 200,000 people in 20 towns and cities were affected.

Torrential rain caused deadly mudslides and **flooding in Brazil** in one of its deadliest natural disasters on record. Almost 500 people were killed across three cities north of Rio de Janeiro.

On February 22, a huge **earthquake** ripped apart the center of **Christchurch**, one of New Zealand's biggest cities. The quake, measuring 6.3 on the Richter scale, hit at the height of the working day and killed an

